

Draft STORY Response: Associates AI Software Engineering (AAISE) Bridge and HLC 3.G

S – Set the Stage

Southwest Wisconsin Technical College recognized that students entering the software pathway now face a workforce shaped by multiple forms of software practice: Native, AI-Assisted, AI-Injected, and AI-Embedded. The existing IT Software Developer curriculum provided a strong foundation in programming, databases, web development, cloud, containers, and application development. However, curriculum review showed a need for more explicit preparation in governed AI use, AI-supported workflow, modern data modeling, validation, professional delivery, and human judgment.

Because students were already progressing under the original program structure, SWTC pursued a bridge approach rather than an abrupt replacement. The AAISE bridge allows the college to honor existing student pathways while intentionally injecting AI-era capabilities into the curriculum.

T – Tell the Data

Because the AAISE bridge is new, SWTC does not yet have quantitative student success outcomes such as retention, completion, placement, or peer benchmark comparisons. The current evidence is qualitative and design-based, including curriculum gap analysis, bridge course replacement analysis, updated course names and descriptions, and the AAISE graduate capability model.

That evidence showed that the current program aligned most strongly with conventional software development preparation. It also contained useful AI-era anchors, including systems analysis, machine learning, data systems, cloud, and Python. However, AI-assisted development, AI-injected system design, AI-embedded systems awareness, validation of AI outputs, collaborative delivery, and human governance were not yet distributed as program-wide expectations.

O – Outline the Action

In response, SWTC redesigned the curriculum as an AI-injected bridge toward the Associate Degree in AI Software Engineering. Rather than treating AI as a single course or late-program topic, the bridge distributes AI-relevant capabilities across the student experience.

Early coursework emphasizes programming foundations, web development, and algorithmic problem solving while introducing guided use of AI-assisted tools. Later coursework strengthens database query and design, modern data modeling, advanced Python systems, C# application development, systems analysis and design, machine learning foundations, cloud platforms, containerized deployment, Agile delivery and DevOps, deep learning frameworks, and a proposed and approved Technical Intelligence Studio that has not yet been fully developed.

R – Reveal the Results

The immediate result is a more coherent curriculum bridge for students entering the software pathway. SWTC has not yet produced statistical outcome improvements because the bridge is still new. However, it has produced a documented rationale for change, a graduate capability model, revised course descriptions, and a clearer progression from foundational software development toward responsible AI-enabled practice.

The bridge also establishes the basis for future assessment under HLC 3.G. **Student Success Outcomes.** As students progress through the redesigned pathway, SWTC will be positioned to collect evidence related to course success, persistence, completion, applied project performance, student confidence, employer feedback, and graduates' ability to explain, validate, and justify AI-supported software decisions.

Y – Yield the Insight

The AAISE bridge demonstrates continuous improvement at the curriculum design stage. SWTC used qualitative evidence from program review and workforce-facing curriculum analysis to identify gaps, preserve student pathways, and strengthen preparation for a changing software field.

For HLC 3.G, the bridge should be understood as an intentional foundation for future student success outcomes. It does not yet claim measurable improvement in retention, completion, or employment outcomes. Instead, it shows that SWTC is proactively defining what successful graduates should be able to do: think clearly, build responsibly, work collaboratively, use AI with judgment, validate uncertain outputs, and adapt as software practice continues to change.

Initially drafted on August 8, 2026 with AI assistance. Reviewed and revised on August 08, 2026 by Cash Myers to adhere to AI ethics, compliance standards, and institutional guidelines.

Extensive artifacts supporting the bridge design, curriculum revisions, and graduate capability model are available for review and where used by AI to help draft the STORY response.